Local SEO Masterclass

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Ranking a Local Google ...

Introduction to Local SEO

NAP Consistency + Map Emb...

Getting ONLY 5 Star Reviews f...

Getting a Google My Busines...

GMB Location + Direction Ma...

Rank and Rent (Organic S...

Introduction to Rank and Rents

Setting up a Rank and Rent

Ranking your Rank and Rent

Pricing your Rank and Rent

Pitching Rank and Rents

Local SEO for Beginners (...

Introduction

Module 1: Introduction to Loc...

Module 2: Setting Up Your Go...

Module 13: Conducting a Local SEO Audit

Overview: This module teaches you how to perform a **Local SEO audit** on a website – essentially a systematic review to identify what's working and what needs improvement. You might do auditing when first onboarding a new client (to find quick wins and major issues) and periodically to ensure everything remains optimized. We'll cover auditing on-page elements (titles, content, etc.), Google Business Profile status, citation consistency, backlink profile, and technical SEO aspects. Think of it as a checklist-driven deep dive into the site's local SEO health. By learning to audit effectively, you can catch problems (like a missing meta description or inaccurate citation) that could be holding back rankings and fix them. This module will strengthen your ability to troubleshoot and maintain SEO results over the long term.

Lessons:

1. **Audit Overview and Tools** – We start by explaining the purpose of an SEO audit: to create an actionable list of fixes and improvements. We mention useful tools: e.g., **Screaming Frog SEO Spider** (to crawl your site and gather on-page data), Google Search Console (for coverage issues and performance), and various free site audit tools or browser extensions (like SEO Minion or MozBar) to check things like headings and meta tags. An audit can be done with automated scans and manual checks.

2. **On-Page SEO Audit** – Step through the site page by page (or use a crawler tool) to review on-page elements. Check that every page has a unique, descriptive title tag (with location where appropriate) and a meta description. Ensure one clear H1 is heading per page and it's relevant. Look at the content: does it naturally include target keywords and



Module 4: Local Keyword Res…

Module 5: On-Page SEO for Y…

Module 6: Local Business Sch…

Module 7: Key Local SEO Ran…

Module 8: Building Citations

Module 9: Advanced Google …

Module 10: Online Reviews & …

Module 11: Local Link Buildin…

Module 12: Setting Up Analyti…

Module 13: Conducting a Loc…

Module 14: Competitor SEO A…

Module 15: Tracking and Rep…

Module 16: Bringing It All Tog…

list of pages that need better optimization or content updates.

3. **Google Business & Citations Audit** – Confirm the Google Business Profile details match the website (name, address, phone). If the GMB listing has any issues (like suspended or missing info), note that. Then sample a handful of major citations and check their accuracy. If you find inconsistencies (say one directory has an old phone number), mark it for correction. If some key citation sites are missing your listing, add those to your to-do list to create. Essentially verify the off-page consistency we established.

4. **Backlink Audit** – Using a tool (like Ahrefs' free backlink checker or Search Console's link report), examine the site's backlink profile. Identify if there are any toxic or spammy links (unlikely to be a huge issue for a small local site unless it's been around long or hacked). Also, note the number of quality links – are there opportunities to disavow bad links or, more positively, opportunities to get new good links where lacking? For example, during audit you might realize "Oh, our competitor has a link from Local University blog, and we don't – maybe we should try to get one." Make note of link building opportunities as part of the audit.

5. **Technical SEO Audit** – Check the site's technical health: Does it load fast? Is it mobile-friendly (you can use Search Console's Mobile Usability report or just test on your phone)? Are there any crawl errors in Search Console (404 pages, etc.)? Ensure the site is indexed properly: search Google for "site:yourdomain.com" to see what pages are indexed – anything important missing or weird pages showing up? Also confirm there's no duplicate content issues or non-HTTPS issues (the site should ideally be on HTTPS). Technical issues can indirectly affect local SEO by hurting user experience or crawlability.

6. **Competitor Benchmarking** – A good audit also peeks at competitors. Identify the top 1-2 local competitors in search and audit them at a high level: What are they doing that you



have 20 – so reviews need boosting. If their site has features (like an FAQ section with local questions), note that as something to emulate. This helps set priorities by seeing where you might be falling behind.

7. **Audit Report and Action Plan** – After gathering all this data, summarize it in an audit report. List all issues found (e.g., "Home page title too short/not targeting keyword," "NAP inconsistency on Yelp listing," "Site not mobile-friendly on some pages," etc.) and then turn that into an **action plan** – a prioritized list of fixes. High priority to anything critical like wrong business info or missing title tags, medium to things like adding more content, and low to minor nice-to-haves. We stress the importance of presenting this clearly to clients if you do it for them, as it demonstrates expertise and gives them confidence in your strategy.

Implementation Steps:

- **Crawl the Website:** Use a free crawler (Screaming Frog in lite mode or an online tool) to scan up to a few hundred URLs. Look at the output for missing or duplicate title tags, meta descriptions, multiple H1s, etc. Note down any pages where the title or description is empty or not optimized (e.g., "Home" as a title – too generic) and plan new ones with keywords.

- **Manual Site Check:** Click through the site as if you were a user. Is the content up to date? Are there any obvious errors (broken links, outdated hours listed, etc.)? Check on a mobile device – does everything display properly? If something's off (like a form not working on mobile), log that to fix.

- **Google Search Console Review:** In GSC, look at **Coverage** and **Mobile Usability**. Fix any errors flagged (if a URL is "Submitted but blocked by robots.txt" for example, figure out if that page should be indexed or not and adjust). Also look at **Security & Manual Actions** – hopefully none, but if there are any warnings (like hacked content or manual penalties), those need urgent attention.

inaccuracies, initiate updates. Also Google the business name and see if any other directories pop up that you didn't cover – add ensuring those are consistent to your list.

- **Evaluate Backlinks:** In Search Console's "Links" section, note how many domains link to you. If it's very few, that indicates link building should be a priority. If there are spammy-looking links (like from unrelated foreign sites), consider using Google's disavow tool if they seem to be causing issues (though usually it's fine to ignore a few spam links). More constructively, identify one or two strong links your top competitor has that you don't, and plan how to get something similar.

- **Compile Findings:** Write down every issue or improvement you found. For example: "Meta descriptions missing on 3 pages", "No LocalBusiness schema – could add" (if you hadn't done Module 6, for instance), "Images are large, affecting speed – compress them", "Only 20 citations found, competitor has 50 – build more citations", etc. Then rank them by impact. Prepare an "Audit Action Plan" document. Optionally, prepare a client-friendly summary if this is for a client, highlighting major issues and the intended fixes and benefits.

- **Address Quick Fixes Immediately:** Some audit fixes are easy – like adding a meta description or fixing a broken link. Knock those out right away. Schedule bigger tasks (redesigning for mobile, content overhaul) into your project timeline. Use the audit as your roadmap moving forward to ensure nothing is overlooked.

Milestone: *By the end of Module 13, you will have completed a thorough Local SEO audit of the website and surrounding online presence, and you'll have a clear list of action items to improve SEO performance.* The milestone is essentially the audit report and checklist. This is a powerful deliverable – it identifies all the gaps and opportunities. With this in hand, you can systematically fix issues and thus potentially gain quick SEO wins. It also prepares you to answer the client's question "How are we doing and what else can we do?" with confidence.

